who went on through Morshing, that even if the Chinese were waiting in ambush, they could not be present in large numbers.

The climb to the top of the plateau just adjacent to the Gompa took almost seven hours, by which time the Morshing column had already gone through to safety in the valley below. The Chinese no doubt let them pass without interference because they were aware of the other column closing in on them. At 11 a.m., when Avasthy's party crested the plateau, the Chinese opened fire from well-concealed positions. The Indians went to ground. They now had two options: break contact, scatter back downhill and continue to flee in small groups, or make one last stand despite the fact that they had no artillery or mortars to support them. Fed up with running, and itching for a fight, Avasthy decided on the latter.

After taking stock of the situation, Avasthy split his men into two groups and launched a two-pronged attack on the Chinese positions. Here the tables were turned, for it was the Chinese who were now fighting from within improvised bunkers and concealed positions. The Indians had no choice but to assault the Chinese positions frontally in broad daylight. One after the other, in a battle that lasted over two hours, every last man was killed.

The Indians had fought it out on the plateau, with no quarter asked for and none given. The exact number of men who died at Lagyala Gompa will never be known. Some estimates put the figure as high as 400, but in all likelihood it was close to 170, a number that included seven officers. Along with Lieutenant Colonel Avasthy, among the dead were the two cousins, Lieutenants Manvir Singh and Chattarpati Singh. The latter was the son of Colonel Girdhari Singh, MC Bar and VrC, one of the most decorated soldiers in the Indian Army.

There were no eyewitnesses to the battle and no survivors to tell the tale. The Chinese had also suffered grievously, losing a large number of men whose bodies were initially stacked in the small courtyard of the Gompa. After the action, the Chinese had dug a mass grave and buried the Indian officers and some of the men. On a solitary tree, on a flattened mess tin, they inscribed the names of Avasthy and the others. They took their own dead away, on a long trail of mules and yaks, each animal loaded with three to four dead bodies which were reportedly cremated at Dirang Dzong.

Major Kukrety, the erstwhile company commander of 4 Rajput's Bravo Company on the Bhutan border, would return to Lagyala Gompa after the